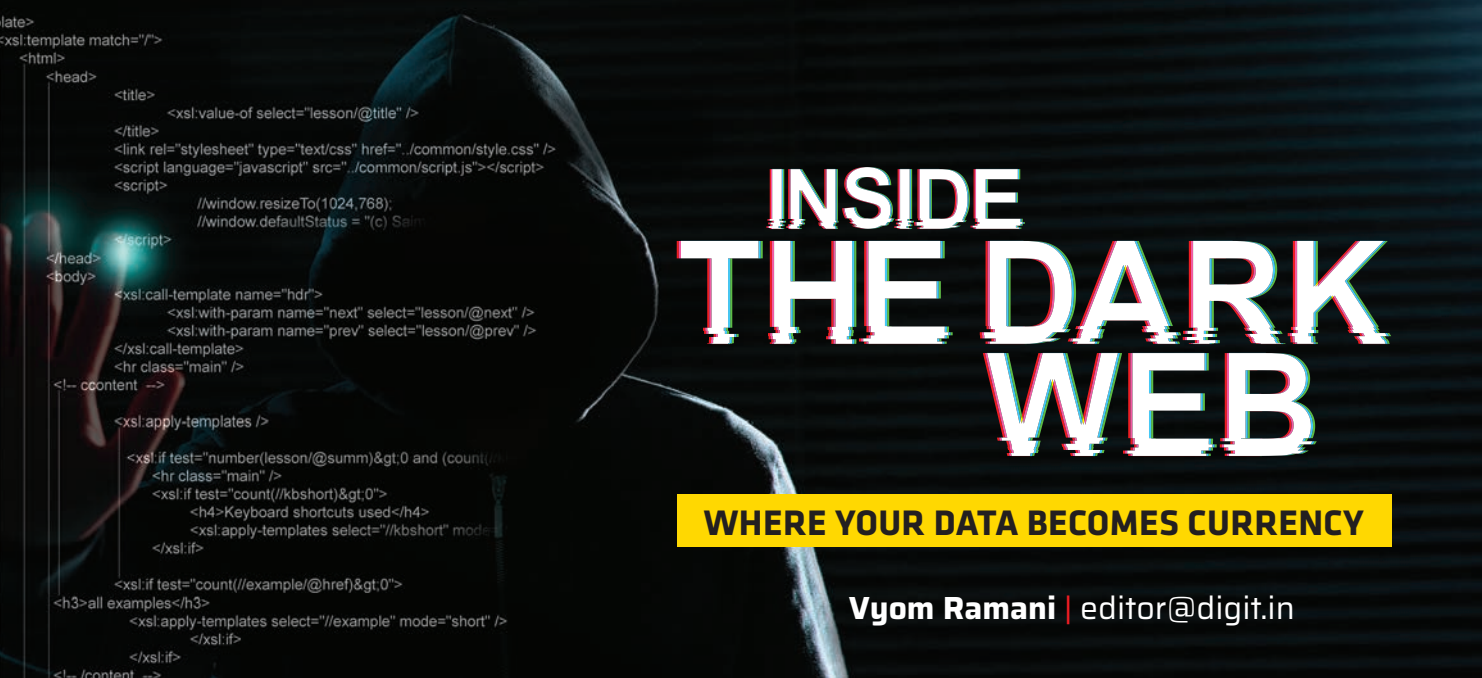




```
<!-- xsl:template match="/" -->
<html>
<head>
<title>
<xsl:value-of select="lesson/@title" />
</title>
<link rel="stylesheet" type="text/css" href="..common/style.css" />
<script language="javascript" src="..common/script.js"></script>
</script>
//window.resizeTo(1024,768);
//window.defaultStatus = "(c) Salim"
</script>
</head>
<body>
<xsl:call-template name="hdr">
<xsl:with-param name="next" select="lesson/@next" />
<xsl:with-param name="prev" select="lesson/@prev" />
</xsl:call-template>
<hr class="main" />
<!-- content -->
<xsl:apply-templates />
<xsl:if test="number(lesson/@summ)>0 and (count(lesson/@next)=0)">
<hr class="main" />
<xsl:if test="count(/kbshort)>0">
<h4>Keyboard shortcuts used</h4>
<xsl:apply-templates select="//kbshort" mode="text" />
</xsl:if>
<xsl:if test="count(/example/@href)>0">
<h3>all examples</h3>
<xsl:apply-templates select="//example" mode="short" />
</xsl:if>
</xsl:if>
<!-- content -->
```

# INSIDE THE DARK WEB

WHERE YOUR DATA BECOMES CURRENCY

Vyom Ramani | editor@digit.in

Imagine scrolling through Amazon or Flipkart, adding items with a tap. But beneath these bright screens lies the Dark Web — a hidden marketplace where your personal data and digital identity are bought and sold.

We think of the internet as shopping sites, and social media, but that's just the surface. Beneath it are private areas like emails and banking apps, and even deeper is the Dark Web, wrapped in encryption and anonymity.

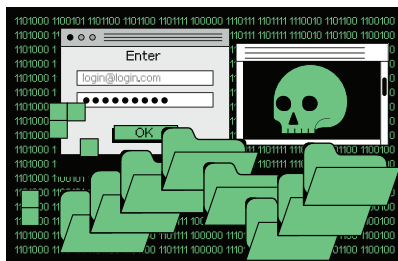
It's a world that doesn't play by any rules. It's a place for secrets, for illicit deals, and for crimes that thrive in the darkness. It's a place where your data — your name, your passwords, your credit card numbers — can find a new life in the hands of strangers.

## Forbidden market for data

In these shadowy corners, stolen data is treated like a commodity. Criminals browse for it as easily as you might for a pair of sneakers. It's chillingly simple: type in a keyword, find a seller, pay in cryptocurrency, and in minutes, they've got what they need. Your name, your birth date, your bank account details, all neatly bundled and ready for misuse.

This is the journey your data takes after a breach. It doesn't just vanish; it's uploaded to forums, traded in data dumps, and repackaged for resale.

A single breach can feed countless criminal schemes, turning your personal information into a product with an endless shelf life. But stolen data is just the tip of the iceberg. The Dark Web is an economy of crime, a sprawling bazaar that caters to every digital misdeed:



- **Identity Theft:** With your details, criminals can get credit cards, take loans, or buy property in your name, leaving you to clean up the mess.
- **Financial Fraud:** Stolen credit card numbers are used to make purchases or empty your accounts, and you might not even realize it's happened until it's too late.
- **Account Takeovers:** Once criminals have your passwords, they can access your social media, or work accounts, turning your digital life upside down.
- **Phishing and Scams:** Personal details make phishing messages frighteningly believable, scammers can craft emails that sound like

they're from your bank, your boss, or even your family.

- **Medical Fraud:** Stolen health records can be used to get prescriptions or treatments, sometimes leaving you with the bill and the damage to your insurance history.
  - **Corporate Espionage:** Businesses aren't immune. Stolen trade secrets or confidential data can be sold to competitors or used for blackmail.
- It doesn't stop there. The Dark Web is a hub for money laundering, turning dirty money into clean funds with a few sleights of hand. Illegal gambling thrives here, hidden from regulators and law enforcement. Drugs, weapons, counterfeit goods, they're all there, fueling an underground economy that flourishes in the absence of oversight.

## Price on your digital self

It's easy to underestimate how valuable your information really is. After all, what's the harm in an old password or a forgotten email address? But criminals see it differently. They know that even a single piece of personal information can be a key to unlock more data, more accounts, and more ways to exploit you.

Your digital self, all bits of data that make your online life, is worth more than you know. Once it's out there, it's impossible to reel it back in. Unlike physical goods, data can be copied end-